

Tarleton State University — AI Initiative

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PAC Retreat: Findings and the Beginning of an AI Roadmap

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Executive Summary

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The Presidential Advisory Committee (PAC) retreat produced a broad portfolio of AI opportunities — more than twenty distinct project ideas spanning every corner of the university. That volume is a strength; left unstructured, it is also a risk, because these projects compete for very different resources.

Analysis of the retreat's outputs yields three findings:

Finding 1 — The portfolio sorts naturally into three buckets defined by the resources each requires, not by theme. Organizing the roadmap this way lets leadership make resource-allocation decisions bucket by bucket rather than project by project, and gives PAC a common structure for prioritization.

	Bucket 1: Workforce Upskilling	Bucket 2: High-Technical Projects	Bucket 3: Curriculum Integration
People required	Many	Few	Many
AI skill depth	Shallow (literacy level)	Deep (engineering level)	Low AI skill; deep subject-matter expertise
Primary burden	Coordination, consistency, organization	Technical build and delivery	Cross-department coordination
Primary owner	Organizational lead (to be named)	SI	Academic Affairs / departments (to be named)
SI role	Advisory	Owner	Advisory

Finding 2 — The university has a critical capability gap in last-mile delivery. Prototypes can be built today; the capability to turn them into reliable, secure, user-facing tools (MLOps/DevOps) does not currently exist anywhere in the institution. Nearly every project in the portfolio depends on it.

Finding 3 — A micro-credentialing opportunity spans the portfolio and points outward, serving both enrolled students and regional professionals — with revenue potential attached.

Recommended decisions:

1. **Adopt the three-bucket framework** as the organizing structure for the AI roadmap and its budget conversations.
2. **Send the bucketed project portfolio back to PAC for a priority vote** — the immediate next step, converting retreat momentum into a ranked project list while attention is high.

3. **Confirm SI's positioning:** SI owns Bucket 2 (high-leverage technical work) and serves Buckets 1 and 3 in an advisory capacity only.
 4. **Fund the last-mile delivery gap** with dedicated MLOps/DevOps personnel — new people for new tasks, funded on the expectation that the tools they ship reduce personnel demand elsewhere.
 5. **Charter the micro-credentialing initiative** as a formal design effort serving both students and the regional workforce.
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Why Buckets by Resource, Not by Theme

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A thematic grouping (student success, research, operations) describes *what the work is about*. It does not tell leadership *what the work costs* or *who must do it*. The retreat's use cases divide cleanly along resource lines — personnel, skill depth, compute, and coordination burden:

- Some need **many people with shallow AI knowledge** — a training and coordination challenge.
- Some need **a few people with rare, deep technical skill** — a hiring and retention challenge.
- Some need **little AI skill but deep disciplinary expertise across many departments** — a faculty-engagement and coordination challenge.

Each profile calls for a different funding instrument, a different owner, and a different measure of success. That is the basis of the framework below.

Bucket 1: Workforce Upskilling

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Resource profile: a relatively large number of people acquiring shallow, practical AI knowledge — teaching a staff member to use an approved AI assistant to summarize email and draft responses does not require engineering depth, but it must reach nearly everyone. The technical burden is small; the organizational burden — coordination, consistency, scheduling, and messaging — is the real work.

Portfolio items in this bucket:

- AI literacy training for faculty, staff, and (outside the curriculum) students
- Faculty development and buy-in — the retreat's case-study analysis flagged faculty trust gaps and premature classroom AI use as a leading institutional risk
- Employee productivity: applying approved AI tools in daily work
- AI literacy for leadership — enough fluency to govern AI, anticipate hidden costs, and avoid over-committing to any single vendor in a still-evolving market
- Internal communication and change management around AI adoption

What success looks like: a consistent, university-wide baseline of AI literacy delivered through an organized program rather than ad hoc workshops — closing the implementation and scaling weaknesses the case-study review identified at peer institutions. The mature end-state is **AI-capable staff embedded in each unit**, serving as their unit's first line of support rather than routing every question to a central office.

Ownership: this is primarily an organizational undertaking and belongs with a named organizational owner who has program-management capacity. SI's role is advisory: curating tools, setting technical guardrails, and supplying subject-matter input to trainers.

Bucket 2: High-Technical Projects — SI's Primary Focus

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Resource profile: a small number of people with high technical skill, plus the standing to work across data owners and business units. People with this depth are genuinely hard to find and hire. This is where scarce engineering talent produces the most leverage, and it is **SI's primary focus area** — spending that rare skill set on the wide-coordination work of Buckets 1 or 3 would be a poor trade. SI's charge is to change the underlying systems that create the work, not to staff its day-to-day execution.

Flagship project: the **AI teammate system** — the most ambitious technical build in the portfolio and the pattern-setter for how AI agents will operate inside university workflows. Versions of this idea surfaced repeatedly at the retreat, and the discussion sharpened its scope: beyond serving a single department, the deeper value is **interdepartmental awareness** — Department A knowing what Department B actually does. Today, students are routed among offices (financial aid, scholarships, business services) that hold overlapping responsibilities and sometimes give conflicting answers; staff lose time to the same blind spots. A connected AI teammate directly attacks that coordination failure.

Other portfolio items in this bucket — each a technical build over institutional data:

- **Predictions and planning:** enrollment forecasting, course-section planning, faculty/staff hiring projections
- **Student success and retention:** disengagement detection, early-alert reporting, faculty flagging
- **Decision support:** financial and pedagogical, for data-driven resource allocation
- **Research and grant capacity:** AI agents for research support and grant writing; automated grant administration and compliance
- **Advancement and enrollment:** alumni engagement prediction, fundraising opportunity identification, recruiting support
- **Administrative streamlining:** visa processing, cross-divisional collaboration and synergy discovery, internal communication tooling, security gap analysis

Not all of these launch at once. The PAC priority vote will drive sequencing; the point for this report is that they all draw on the *same scarce resource pool* and must therefore be prioritized together, under one owner.

The Critical Gap: Last-Mile Delivery

This is the most consequential resource finding of the analysis. The university's current capability ends at the **working prototype**. What is missing is the capability to carry a prototype the last mile into a **reliable, sustainable, secure, user-facing tool**: hardened access control, data privacy compliance, monitoring, incident response, version management, and ongoing support. The retreat's case-study analysis flagged exactly these weaknesses at peer institutions — missing incident-response protocols, security and privacy exposure, and stalled scaling.

The need is not obvious on the surface of the project list, but nearly every project on it ends with people using a tool, and every such tool requires this delivery work. Today that burden falls on senior data-science staff — as it has for tools already shipped, such as the syllabus review tool — which is not the highest-leverage use of the university's scarcest technical skill set.

Closing the gap requires dedicated MLOps/DevOps personnel — a capability the uni-

versity does not currently employ. Without it, every Bucket 2 project stalls at the demo stage and the projected efficiency returns never materialize. This is the single most urgent hiring priority in the AI initiative.

Bucket 3: Academic / Curriculum Integration

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Resource profile: low AI-skill requirement, but deep subject-matter expertise and extensive coordination across many departments. Peer institutions are moving to embed AI education in every discipline, not just computing — and the preliminary prioritization analysis (Appendix B) places curriculum-wide AI literacy at the top of the institutional list.

Portfolio items in this bucket:

- AI integration into department curricula — English, engineering, and ultimately every discipline
- University-wide *and* discipline-specific AI competencies, informed by external advisory boards
- Defining the “AI core”: what every Tarleton graduate should know, and what “AI career-ready” means by field
- Real-world, client-engaged AI projects embedded in coursework

The work here is disciplinary, not technical. A faculty member deciding how AI belongs in a writing course needs curricular judgment, not engineering skill. What the institution must supply is *coordination*: shared competency frameworks, consistent guardrails, and a forum that keeps dozens of departments moving in the same direction. The faculty-trust concerns surfaced at the retreat make careful, faculty-led design essential.

Ownership: Academic Affairs and the departments, through normal curriculum governance. SI’s role is advisory: recommending tools, defining technical feasibility, and supplying guardrails.

Micro-credentialing Initiative

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First proposed at the retreat by President Hurley, micro-credentialing warrants standalone attention because it spans Buckets 1 and 3 and points outward: **AI credential paths serving degree-seeking students, and equally serving regional businesses and individuals** who want to upskill in AI without committing to a four-year degree — and are willing to pay for it.

The differentiator is the person. Tarleton would not be competing with large online-only providers for learners satisfied with a self-paced course. The target audience is the regional learner who wants a physical instructor to learn from and ask questions of. The curriculum itself can build on the same industry-standard content those providers use — the value-add is the human instruction and community wrapped around it.

Strategic value:

- **Workforce and economic impact** — extends Tarleton’s reach into regional workforce development and serves the community directly
- **Revenue potential** — credential programs for working professionals are a fundable, tuition-adjacent income stream
- **Efficiency** — the same competency frameworks and training content built for Buckets 1

and 3 can be packaged into credentials, so the marginal cost is packaging and delivery, not new content

Recommendation: charter a small design group under President Hurley’s sponsorship to define the initial credential ladder, delivery model, and pricing, reporting back in the next roadmap iteration.

Resource Requirements and Funding Rationale

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The funding logic across all three buckets is the same: **new people for new tasks — tasks that, once performed, reduce the need for additional people elsewhere.** This is not headcount growth for its own sake; it is a reallocation of where human effort is spent.

Need	Bucket	Why now	What it offsets
MLOps/DevOps capability (highest priority)	2	The last-mile gap blocks every technical project from reaching users	Each shipped tool (enrollment forecasting, grant administration, early alerts) reduces manual administrative load across multiple offices
Program coordination for upskilling	1	Training at scale fails without consistent organization	An AI-literate workforce needs less ad hoc support and rework, and adopts efficiency tools faster
Curriculum coordination capacity	3	Dozens of departments must move consistently	Prevents duplicated, department-by-department reinvention of AI policy and course design

The retreat’s project list is, in large part, a list of **efficiency claims:** streamlined administration, automated compliance, predictive planning, productivity gains. Those claims only cash out if the tools actually ship — which returns to the MLOps/DevOps investment as the linchpin.

Cross-Cutting Foundations

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Two threads from the retreat’s case-study analysis apply to all buckets and should ride along with the roadmap rather than form a fourth bucket:

- **Governance and ethics:** the PAC consistently emphasized responsible, human-centered AI with human oversight — and flagged governance structures and outcome measurement

as the areas peer institutions most often get wrong. Foundational governance documents and an acceptable-use framework should mature alongside the first projects, not after them.

- **Security, privacy, and incident response:** identified gaps at peer institutions; addressed structurally by the last-mile delivery capability recommended above.

Recommended Decisions and Next Steps

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1. **Adopt the three-bucket framework** as the structure for AI roadmap planning and resource allocation.
2. **Approve sending the bucketed portfolio back to PAC for a priority vote** — the immediate next step, converting retreat momentum into a ranked project list while attention is high.
3. **Confirm SI ownership of Bucket 2** and its advisory-only role in Buckets 1 and 3.
4. **Approve recruitment of MLOps/DevOps personnel** to close the last-mile delivery gap — the linchpin investment behind every technical project's return.
5. **Name organizational owners for Buckets 1 and 3.**
6. **Charter the micro-credentialing design group** under President Hurley's sponsorship.

With the framework, the vote results, and named owners in place, the next roadmap iteration sequences the project portfolio and sets 90-day milestones. This document is the beginning of that roadmap: it is structured so that each subsequent decision — a hire, a project start, a program launch — lands in a bucket whose resource logic has already been agreed.

Appendix A: Retreat Use Cases Mapped to Buckets

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Retreat use case	Bucket	Notes
AI literacy training (faculty, staff, students)	1	Broad, shallow, organization-heavy
Faculty development & buy-in	1	Addresses trust gap flagged in case studies
Leadership AI literacy	1	Governance fluency, vendor caution
Employee productivity & capacity building	1	Tool adoption in daily work
Internal communication / change management	1	Supports all adoption efforts
AI teammate system	2	Flagship technical build; interdepartmental scope
Enrollment prediction & course-section planning	2	Institutional data + modeling
Student disengagement detection / early alerts	2	Top-three preliminary priority
Financial & pedagogical decision support	2	Institutional data + modeling

Retreat use case	Bucket	Notes
Research & grant-writing agents	2	Agent development
Grant administration & compliance automation	2	Workflow automation
Alumni engagement prediction	2	Predictive modeling
Fundraising & promotion opportunity identification	2	Predictive modeling
Recruiting support	2	Workflow + modeling
Visa process streamlining	2	Workflow automation
Cross-divisional collaboration / synergy discovery	2	Institutional data mining
Learning augmentation tools (“teach me ___”)	2	Built in 2; classroom use touches 3
Security gap analysis	2	Technical assessment
AI across department curricula (English, engineering, ...)	3	Deep subject expertise, wide coordination
University-wide & discipline-specific competencies	3	With external advisory boards
“AI core” / AI career-ready graduate definition	3	Curricular governance
Client-engaged, real-world AI coursework	3	Departmental design
Micro-credentialing	1 + 3	Spans both; external workforce reach

Appendix B: Preliminary Prioritization Signal

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Ahead of the formal PAC priority vote, an AI-assisted analysis of the retreat’s use cases (benchmarked against peer-institution adoption trends) suggested three leading priorities:

1. **AI literacy across the curriculum** (Bucket 3, supported by Bucket 1)
2. **Operational efficiency and decision support** (Bucket 2)
3. **Student success and retention** (Bucket 2)

This is an input to the PAC vote, not a substitute for it. Notably, the top candidates span all three buckets — confirming that no single resource profile can carry the initiative alone.